

CASE ID: 202109710713

EPISODE NAME: China Bans Taiwanese Wax and Custard Apples

2021/09/19 - Ongoing

Sender: China (710)

Target: Taiwan (713)

Issue: Contain Political Influence (1)

Final Outcome: Stalemate after Sanctions Imposition (9)

Narrative:

On 2021/09/19, China announced a ban on Taiwanese wax and custard apples without warning.¹ Although China cited the discovery of a type of mealybug in the two fruit imports as cause for the ban, Taiwanese officials suggested the import restrictions were politically motivated.²

The ban was economically consequential, as 90% of Taiwan's exported custard and wax apples were sold to China.³ Some reporting claimed the restrictions were aimed at dissuading farmers from voting for the Democratic Progressive Party, which is less acquiescent to Chinese interests than the Kuomintang (KMT), their political rivals.⁴

Imports of custard apples began to reopen when China announced that orchards in Taitung County were approved on 2023/06/20.⁵ Reports suggest that the decision was in response to the Taitung County Government sending representatives to the Straits Forum in Fujian Province on 2023/06/17 and 2023/06/18.⁶ Taiwanese lawmakers suggested that exports would likely only be approved for farmers in KMT-supporting provinces.⁷

Custard apple imports are still more heavily restricted than they were prior to the ban.

¹ Chen Yu-fu, Lin Liang-sheng and Kayleigh Madjar. "Officials condemn China's 'cruel' fruit import ban." *Taipei Times*, 20 Sept. 2021. <https://www.taipeitimes.com/News/taiwan/archives/2021/09/20/2003764670>

² *Ibid.*

³ *Ibid.*

⁴ Hioe, Brian. "China's Wax and Custard Apple Ban Proves "Pineapple War" Redux." *New Bloom*, 27 September 2021. <https://newbloommag.net/2021/09/27/custard-wax-apple-ban/>

⁵ Chen Yu-fu. "Chinese office lifts ban on imports of custard apples." *Taipei Times*, 21 June 2023. <https://www.taipeitimes.com/News/taiwan/archives/2023/06/21/2003801904>

⁶ *Ibid.*

⁷ *Ibid.*